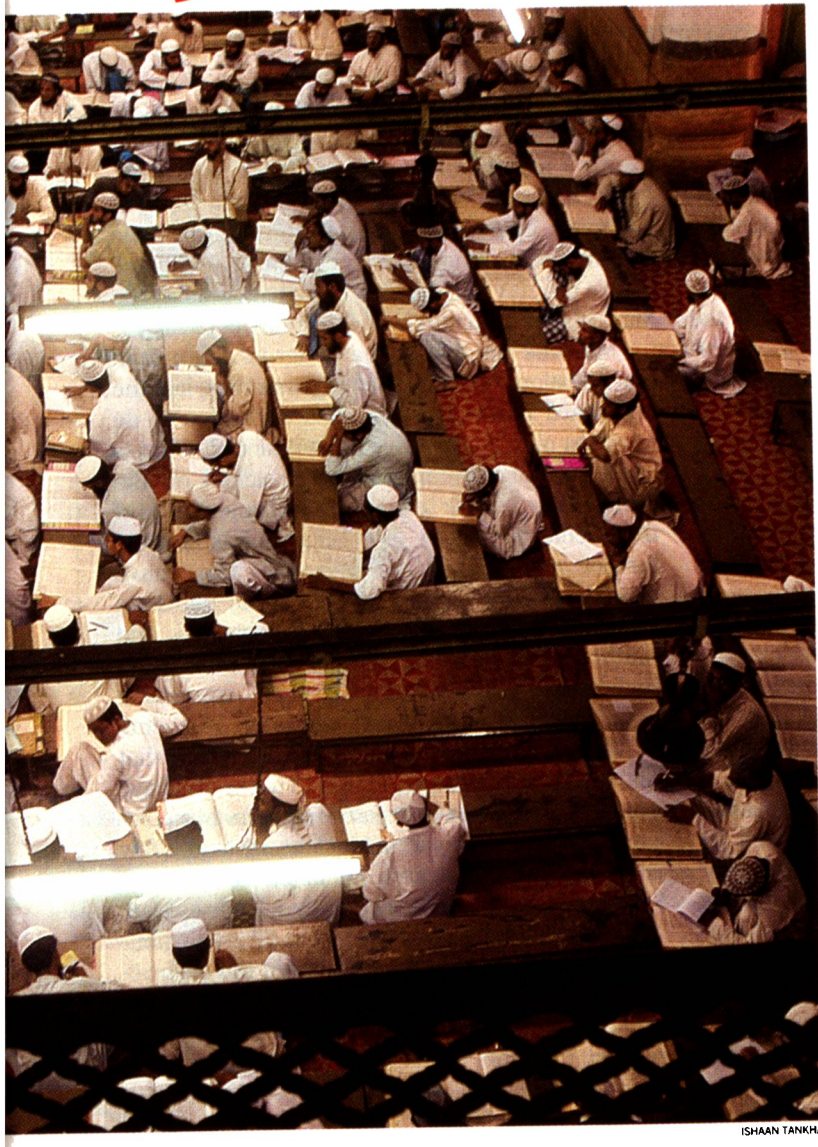


Origin of Fear



NEW SCRIPT:
Students at
a Deoband
seminary

successors indignantly reject any links with Wahhabism, it is a fact that their co-founder Ahmad Rashid Gangohi famously declared the Wahhabis to be 'good people' with 'good beliefs' with whom they 'shared basic beliefs', while a scarcely less important Deobandi contemporary, Sheikh-ul-Hadith Muhammad Zakariya Kandhalvi, no less famously declared, "I am a more staunch Wahhabi than any of you."

Fearing the loss of their Muslim identity and faced with a choice between the forward-looking Islam offered by Syed Ahmed Khan of Alipore and the backward-looking, intolerant interpre-

tation of Islam promoted at Deoband, India's Muslim poor chose to support the latter. By the end of the 19th century, the alumni of the original Deoband Madrasa had founded more than two dozen madrasas in north India. This expansion was presided over by Deoband's first student, Mahmood ul-Hasan, whose history as a jihadi, culminating in the 'Silk Letter Conspiracy' fiasco of 1915, has been misrepresented as a freedom fighter by both nationalist historians as well as by the Dar ul-Ulum Deoband.

Today Dar ul-Ulum Deoband requires its students to be loyal citizens of India, but outside India the movement is very strong—not because its message was welcome but thanks to Saudi Arabia's lavish funding of religious institutions that reflect its Wahhabi state theology. The impact of this expansion has been immense and in the process Sunni Islam in Pakistan, and, Afghanistan in particular, has undergone a seismic shift, becoming increasingly conservative and more inclined to look for political leadership from the madrasa-trained political leader rather than Islam's traditional secular leaders. Almost every leading member of the Taliban is a Deoband madrasa graduand, and the ongoing drive to Talibanise Pakistan originates from the several thousand Deoband and the more overtly Wahhabi Ahl-i-Hadith madrasas that are often the only source of free education in the North-West Frontier Province and the Federally Administrated Tribal Areas.

But Deobandism is by no means confined to South Asia. In Britain, the majority of Pakistanis who settled in the Midlands in the 1960s and '70s belonged to the tolerant Bareilvi school of Islam. But for many of their English-speaking children, Bareilvi Islam is a let-down when preached by an Urdu-speaking Imam. Significant numbers of this alienated younger generation have found in Deobandism an Islam that is deeply attractive in its clear-cut certainties of what is godly and what is sinful. Thanks largely to Saudi funding, there are now in excess of 600 Deobandi mosques in Britain, playing a leading role in reshaping the Sunni Muslim community. There is much that is positive in its interpretation of Islam, but Deobandism is at heart separatist and doubly divisive in splitting the Muslim community and driving a wedge between Muslims and non-Muslims. It is hard to see how such an ideology can have a place in modern Britain, never mind modern India.

Charles Allen is the author of God's Terrorists: The Wahhabi Cult and the Hidden Roots of Modern Jihad